

ANTI-NAXAL SUCCESS

- **On October 4, security forces ambushed and killed 31 Maoists in Bastar—the highest toll ever exacted in Chhattisgarh**
- **Credible intelligence, good planning led to the success—not one security personnel was killed**
- **The bulk of the personnel who took part in the action were locals, as were the Maoists who surrendered**
- **The strike rate so far: 194 Maoists killed, 801 arrested, 742 surrendered in 2024**

leaders high up in the hierarchy.

"The October 4 operation was intelligence-based and its success comes after months of work. All those interested in peace in Bastar should eschew violence, surrender and join the mainstream," Sundarraj P., Inspector General of Police, Bastar, said after the operation.

Chhattisgarh came in for praise at a meeting of Maoist-affected states chaired by Union home minister Amit Shah on October 7 in New Delhi. "We are speeding up development work in Maoist-affected areas to prevent youth from being misguided," CM Vishnu Deo Sai said at the meeting. The Centre has set a March 2026 deadline to finish the guerrilla war for good.

The October 4 strike, though daring in itself, was not the deepest within Maoist-controlled territory. There were sorties deeper into Abujhmad during the monsoon. The forces plan to open 29 more camps with a view to dominate more area and are bracing for more fierce firefights. The safety catches on weapons are off on both sides. ■



SAFFRON SQUABBLE
Sunil Jakhar, Punjab BJP president

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

PUNJAB/ BJP

TIPPING POINT

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

As the autumn leaves begin to fall in Punjab, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) finds itself in familiar territory in the state—embroiled in internal strife just as another crucial election looms on the horizon. With panchayat polls set for October 15, followed by byelections in four assembly seats, the party's focus should be on strengthening its rural base. Instead, a leadership crisis threatens to derail its efforts.

On a recent three-day visit to the state, Vijay Rupani, in-charge of party affairs in Punjab, found himself saddled with the mortifying task of explaining away the conspicuous absence of state unit chief Sunil Jakhar from key meetings. Putting on a brave face, the former Gujarat chief minister told reporters that Jakhar had gone to Delhi for "personal work". A facade of normalcy was just about kept up, but nearly not enough to conceal an interior rife with discontent.

Blame it on a trail of strategic missteps. Jakhar, who had switched from the Congress in 2022, was elevated as Punjab BJP chief within a year—swiftness rare for a party known for its cautious approach to newcomers. The central leadership had high hopes that this son of former Union minister and Lok Sabha Speaker Balram Jakhar, a figure held in esteem in farm circles, would be their key to unlocking the rural vote bank, especially among the Jat Sikhs. However, the gamble appears to have backfired spectacularly. Party insiders now ruefully admit that instead of fresh insights, Jakhar brought with him the "Congress culture of favouritism".

The first blow came in October last year when a group of Congress turncoats, including Gurpreet Kangar, Balbir Sidhu and Raj Kumar Verka, quit the BJP just months after Jakhar's appointment. More recently, the BJP's performance in the Lok Sabha election deepened worries. The party contested all 13 seats for the first time following a separation from its long-time ally, the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD). While the BJP managed to secure 18.56 per cent of votes, most of these came from urban Hindu voters—their traditional support base. Party insiders lament that they lost in six seats due to a significant drop in rural votes, precisely the area where Jakhar was expected to deliver.

BJP leaders in Punjab complain that Jakhar has a "my way or the